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Democracy Dies in Darkness

FRIDAY, AUGUST 22, 2025 • \$4

California rushes to offset new Texas map

Plan to redraw districts to favor Democrats will go to voters in November

BY MAEVE RESTON AND PATRICK SVITEK

California Gov. Gavin Newsom (D) signed several bills Thursday aimed at redrawing California's congressional maps, as Democrats try to counter Republican-driven efforts in Texas to remake its maps.

The back-and-forth marked a pivotal moment in an expanding national battle over electoral terrain — initiated by President Donald Trump — that has become increasingly heated as the two parties fight for control of Congress in next year's midterm elections.

"They fired the first shot, Texas. We wouldn't be here had Texas not done what they just did," Newsom said as he signed California's bills.

California's plans require voters to approve changes to the state's congressional map in a special election that the legislature, with Thursday's votes, set for November. The 11-week campaign in California is expected to be fierce, with powerful forces and deep-pocketed donors promising to raise as much as \$100 million for each side.

In the first week since opening a campaign committee, Newsom has raised more than \$6 million from more than 200,000 small donors, according to his aides. There are no limits on contributions in California to ballot measure committees.

California and Texas are redrawing their maps in hopes of creating new U.S. House districts that would give their parties an advantage in next year's midterm elections. Though those two states have acted first, other states are also moving ahead swiftly. Republicans are eyeing changes in Indiana, Ohio, Missouri and Florida. Democrats are looking at whether they can carve out more seats in Illinois.

The extraordinary fight has included an assertion from Trump that his party is "entitled" to more House seats, a two-week walkout

SEE **REDISTRICTING** ON A22

FAQ: What to know about the fight for an advantage in the House. **A22**

Israel pummels Gaza City as new operation gets underway

U.N. has warned that planned occupation could displace 1 million people

BY CLAIRE PARKER, LIOR SOROKA AND SIHAM SHAMALAKH

JERUSALEM — Israeli strikes pummeled Gaza City and its surroundings Thursday after officials announced the launch of a widely anticipated operation to seize and occupy the enclave's largest metropolis, despite condemnation from the international community, Palestinian residents and many Israelis who turned out this week in record numbers to protest the assault.

Israeli warplanes and helicopters circled Gaza City, hitting buildings there throughout the day, while heavy artillery pound-

ed the neighborhoods of Shejaiya in the east and Sabra in the south, residents reported.

In a brief, prerecorded statement outside the army's Gaza Division headquarters, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said he was there to approve the military's plans to take over the city. His office said Wednesday that he had ordered the military to speed up the timing of the operation, after his security cabinet green-lit the decision to occupy Gaza City at a meeting earlier this month.

"We have begun the preliminary actions, and already now IDF troops are holding the outskirts of Gaza City," Israel Defense Forces spokesman Brig. Gen. Effie Defrin said late Wednesday. He added that Israeli forces were also operating in Jabalya, north of the city, and in the southern neighborhood of Zeitoun.

The planned operation has drawn condemnation from

SEE **GAZA** ON A11



KARLA GACHET/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

'If they don't send money, the town stops'

For decades, young people in this hillside village have had two options: harvest corn or head north.

So many left, to work as gardeners and cooks in Southern California, that the money they sent home fueled an economic transformation.

The small adobe homes in this Zapotec community of about 2,500 people gave way to two-story cement houses with wrought-iron gates. Roads were paved. A basketball court rose near the town center.

The migrants' cash created jobs in construction and helped launch small businesses. In March, local leaders dedicated a peach-colored welcome arch at the town's

A drop in remittances is impacting jobs and leaving homes half-built in Mexico

BY TEO ARMUS AND KARLA GACHET IN SAN BARTOLOMÉ QUIALANA, MEXICO

Tomas Pérez Sánchez, above, plants corn on her land. Her husband used his earnings from gardening work in the U.S. to buy about seven acres of land.

entrance. A plaque at its base honored "the invaluable help of our countrymen working abroad."

But as the Trump administration has pushed many of Quialana's sons and daughters back to Mexico, and prompted many of those who remain in the United States to cut back on work, much of the once-steady construction in the village has come to a halt. Now the gates hide the unfinished walls of "California-style" facades.

Rosa Gómez Hernández, 37, used money sent by her father and a nephew to start a small embroidery business. But with their

SEE **REMITTANCES** ON A12

Erin adds to unusual trend of Category 5 storms

The strongest hurricanes have become more frequent, enhanced by climate change and warm waters

BY IAN LIVINGSTON

Erin became the latest in a string of the strongest type of hurricanes to roam the Atlantic Ocean in recent years. When its sustained winds exploded to 160 mph on Saturday, it became the 11th Category 5 storm in the basin since 2016.

It wasn't always this way, but one has formed roughly every year in the past decade.

To get a sense of how unusual that is: Over the longer term, there have been only 33 seasons with Category 5s since 1924, or about one-third of all years. Before the last 10 years — when there have been 11 Category 5 hurricanes — it

took 27 years for the prior 11 of that level and 34 years for the 11 before that.

The environment that sent Erin into the history books was primed, thanks largely to another year of widespread warm water across the Atlantic Ocean. Erin became yet another storm to rapidly intensify well beyond the criteria for

explosive development, taking advantage of those conditions.

The 10-year running sum of Category 5s is now at its highest mark for modern records. And with the bulk of the season still to

SEE **HURRICANE** ON A7

Sea ice: Melt rate has slowed — but only temporarily, study finds. **A7**



MANDEL NGAN/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

'We're not playing games'

President Donald Trump speaks with about 300 law enforcement and National Guard members Thursday at a U.S. Park Police facility in Southeast Washington. **Story, B14**

Trump's \$500M penalty voided

N.Y. APPEALS COURT: AMOUNT 'EXCESSIVE'

Civil fraud finding tied to real estate empire stands

BY SHAYNA JACOBS AND JEREMY ROEBUCK

NEW YORK — A state appeals court on Thursday voided a massive civil judgment against President Donald Trump, calling the roughly \$500 million verdict "excessive" while leaving in place a lower court's finding that he and others in his real estate empire had committed fraud.

The ruling by a split, five-member panel of New York's First Department Appellate Division was made public Thursday, months after the court heard arguments from state lawyers and attorneys for Trump.

New York Attorney General Letitia James won the civil case against Trump, his company, two of his adult children and two former executives last year when a state court judge determined that they collectively committed a long-running fraud involving false information they provided to potential lenders and insurers about the value of his properties.

"While harm certainly occurred, it was not the cataclysmic harm that can justify a nearly half billion-dollar award of the state," one of the appellate judges, Peter H. Moulton, wrote in an opinion Thursday, one of three opinions filed by the panel.

The panel declined to overturn the lower court's finding that Trump and other Trump Organization executives were liable for committing a series of illegal acts, including falsification of business records, conspiracy and insurance fraud. The judges also left

SEE **TRUMP** ON A5

Trump is at the fore of an anti-urban movement

BY NAFTALI BENDAVID

When President Donald Trump declared his third presidential candidacy in 2022, he saved his most colorful language for America's urban areas, bemoaning "the blood-soaked streets of our once-great cities" and adding that "the cities are rotting, and they are indeed cesspools of blood."

Later in his campaign, Trump called Milwaukee "horrible" and described Washington as a "rat-infested, graffiti-infested shit-hole." More recently he said, "These cities, it's like living in hell."

Other Republicans have seized on similar dystopian urban images. When Vice President JD Vance visited New York several years ago, he compared the city to a zombie apocalypse, posting: "I have heard it's violent and disgusting there. But is it like Walking Dead Season 1 or Season 4?"

As Trump ramps up the military presence in Washington — and hints that he may move to take over other cities — his

SEE **CITIES** ON A4

Vehicle wraps: ICE aims to spend millions on gold auto signage. **B14**

IN THE NEWS

E.U. trade deal Leaders shared details of a pact to keep U.S. levies on European vehicles high for now and lower tariffs on computer chips, but lengthy negotiations lie ahead. **A17**

Cash in a chip bag A volunteer adviser to New York Mayor Eric Adams's campaign was suspended for giving a reporter money. **A3**

THE NATION **A former intelligence analyst** was named the National Security Agency's deputy director. **A5** **New details** about the shooting at the CDC's headquarters emerged amid a wave of firings. **A8**

THE WORLD **Kyiv said** a sequence of strikes across Ukraine showed Moscow is not interested in peace. **A10** **Uganda said** it reached a deal to accept "third country" deportees from the United States. **A11**

THE ECONOMY **A proposed merger** would see three of Indianapolis's local TV stations under one company in a deal with nationwide implications. **A16** **Walmart** has been able to draw shoppers of all income brackets away from rivals even as tariffs push up prices. **A16**

STYLE **Gen Z** explains eight defining generational habits that may baffle other cohorts. **B1** **SPORTS** **In the NCAA's NIL era** of revenue sharing, smaller athletic programs such as Morgan State look for traction in uncertain territory. **B8**

THE REGION **Newly released** standardized test scores show that more students in the District are reading on grade level than before the coronavirus pandemic. **B14** **WEEKEND** **The section** is off this week. Movie listings are in today's Style section.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A16
COMICS.....B4
OBITUARIES.....B16
OPINION PAGES.....A19
TELEVISION.....B7
WORLD NEWS.....A10

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